Along with resistance from the government, Birla also faced opposition from the Europeans who owned most of the jute mills in India. His biggest competitor bought up all the land that he intended to buy. Birla also faced difficulty in securing a loan, and when he finally got one, it was at a higher rate of interest than that levied on British firms.



Birla was known for being careful, meticulous and thorough. He made it a point to be knowledgeable about the work he was doing. For instance, when he ventured into cotton manufacturing, he took the time to educate himself on every aspect of the process, including the most menial tasks.

A mediator and a pragmatist

Like his contemporary Jamnalal Bajaj (also featured in this section), Birla donated generously to the Congress and to Gandhi, with whom he had a close relationship. Interestingly, Birla was sceptical about the effectiveness of civil disobedience; cooperation and partnership were a better way forward in his view. As such, he performed the crucial role of being an